DATA CENTERS WORK

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By AJ Reichelt ● Oct 22, 2026

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Welcome to **Pulse by Cortex: Data Centers Work Daily Brief**, a bespoke newsletter delivering insights, analysis, and a glimpse into the state of play of the data center debate in Alabama and Georgia.

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ALABAMA

🚨 **Lowndes residents sue:** Two residents sued the Lowndes County Commission on Sunday, alleging it violated state open meetings law when it approved $1.1 billion in county tax abatements for Project Red Clay on Oct. 13.

- They allege the three commissioners who voted yes met separately beforehand, and they're asking the court to block further action on the agreement. Commissioner Dickson Farrior, who voted no, said in an affidavit that the process departed from the commission's usual practice.
- At a special meeting Tuesday, commissioners voted 3-2 to approve the Oct. 13 minutes after Farrior objected that the item wasn't on the posted notice. The presiding judge recused himself from the lawsuit Monday.

Both parties weigh in: After the Lowndes vote, Republican lieutenant governor nominee John Wahl called for more transparency on data center incentives. Democrat Doug Jones said the vote "gets people very concerned."

Count Taxula: AL.com cartoonist JD Crowe's Halloween opinion cartoon casts data center developers as vampires feeding on rural tax breaks and calls Lowndes "ground zero."

- The accompanying column points to the commission's 10-minute meeting approving $1.1 billion in abatements for Project Red Clay.

Bessemer mayor vs. QTS: Bessemer Mayor Louise Alexander (who was sworn in on Oct. 5) sent QTS a cease-and-desist letter Monday, saying work on its Project Marvel data center should stop until the company gets city permits and meets with city leaders.

- QTS said it's working under city-approved permits and asked to postpone Friday's meeting with Alexander. It also said it has no plans to expand the campus and that its offers to buy nearby homes are voluntary.

Fairfield tables financing tool: The Fairfield City Council tabled a proposed Commercial Property Assessed Clean Energy (C-PACE) financing program Monday as residents protested a planned Patmos data center at the city's former Walmart site.

- Mayor Herman Carnes said the program isn't a city loan for the project. The council plans a work session on it.

Nebius seeks dismissal: The City of Birmingham and the Nebius developers filed Tuesday to dismiss nearby homeowners' lawsuit over the Oxmoor Valley data center.

- They argued the homeowners should have appealed the zoning through the city first and that noise and heat concerns are speculative. A judge rejected the appeal argument earlier, and trial is set for March 8, 2027.

The Alabama Poll: Alabama voters view data centers unfavorably, 53% to 33%, in a new poll of 600 likely voters.

- 59% said data centers should be allowed only if companies supply their own power and protect ratepayers and water. 28% said they shouldn't be built in Alabama at all.

🚨 **Childersburg weighs a sale:** Childersburg is considering selling more than 1,000 acres at a former Army ammunition plant, now a Superfund site, to a buyer planning a data center. The mayor says the buyer is working with Alabama Power on a power agreement.

- A councilor said Tuesday, "We don't even know who is going to be running the place."

Meta opens its doors: Meta gave local TV crews a tour of its Huntsville data center and said the facility won't raise residents' power bills. It didn't disclose the facility's power or water use.

GEORGIA

$2.5 million for Tolbert: An independent committee called Powering Georgia's Future has put $2.5 million into ads backing Republican Josh Tolbert in the PSC District 5 race. The money comes from a group called Competence Matters Inc., according to an Oct. 20 state ethics filing. The group was formed in August by Marietta election lawyer Bryan Tyson.

- Democrats Shelia Edwards and Peter Hubbard have drawn about $584,000 in combined outside support.

Effingham hires oversight firm: Effingham County commissioners voted Tuesday to hire Charles Abbott Associates to oversee Phase 1 of OpenAI's 1,400-acre Project Camellia campus. The site plans still haven't come up for a vote.

On the opinion page: In an AJC guest column, Rick Jackson, the Republican nominee for governor, said community benefit agreements should be in writing. He also said he would back a bipartisan push to require transparency in data center deals.

Blasting in Columbia County: Blasting starts today at the Greenpoint data center site north of Harlem and runs every other weekday through Dec. 30.

SOUTHERN STATES

Memphis pauses data centers: Memphis City Council voted 7-5 Tuesday for a 135-day pause on new data centers, hours after a longer moratorium deadlocked 6-6. Two council members said they first saw the 135-day ordinance just before the meeting.

- Separately, U.S. District Judge Debra Brown ruled Monday that the Trump administration can't unilaterally dismiss the NAACP's Clean Air Act lawsuit over gas turbines at SpaceXAI's Southaven, Miss., power plant, which serves its Colossus data centers. The government can still join the case.
- The Shelby County Commission took up its own data center rules Wednesday. One proposal would set water and electricity conservation requirements, and the other would impose a moratorium of up to 12 months.

Lining up for data center pay: Hundreds of electricians, some from as far as Idaho, lined up outside the IBEW union hall in Memphis this week for Mid-South data center jobs, with some reporting offers above $8,000 a week.

- "Tell Elon Musk to stay, we love this money you're giving us," one said. SpaceXAI is also paying its own employees 20% more to help build its Colossus supercomputers in Memphis and Southaven, Miss.

Florida's moratorium wave: Martin County, Dade City and Broward County are advancing one-year data center pauses. Lake County is moving to require a commission vote on each project, and more than 600 Osceola County residents have petitioned against a 2,232-acre site being marketed for a hyperscale data center.

Meta reviews its NDAs: Meta said it's reviewing its use of nondisclosure agreements nationwide after WWL questioned the secrecy around its Hyperion data center in Louisiana. Gov. Jeff Landry, and dozens of state officials and agencies have signed NDAs under his administration.

Applied Digital's Louisiana deal: Applied Digital, the developer behind Delta Forge 2 in Brookwood, Ala., agreed to pay Boyce, La., $4 million under a community benefit agreement for its nearby Delta Forge 1 campus. That's more than the town's annual revenue.

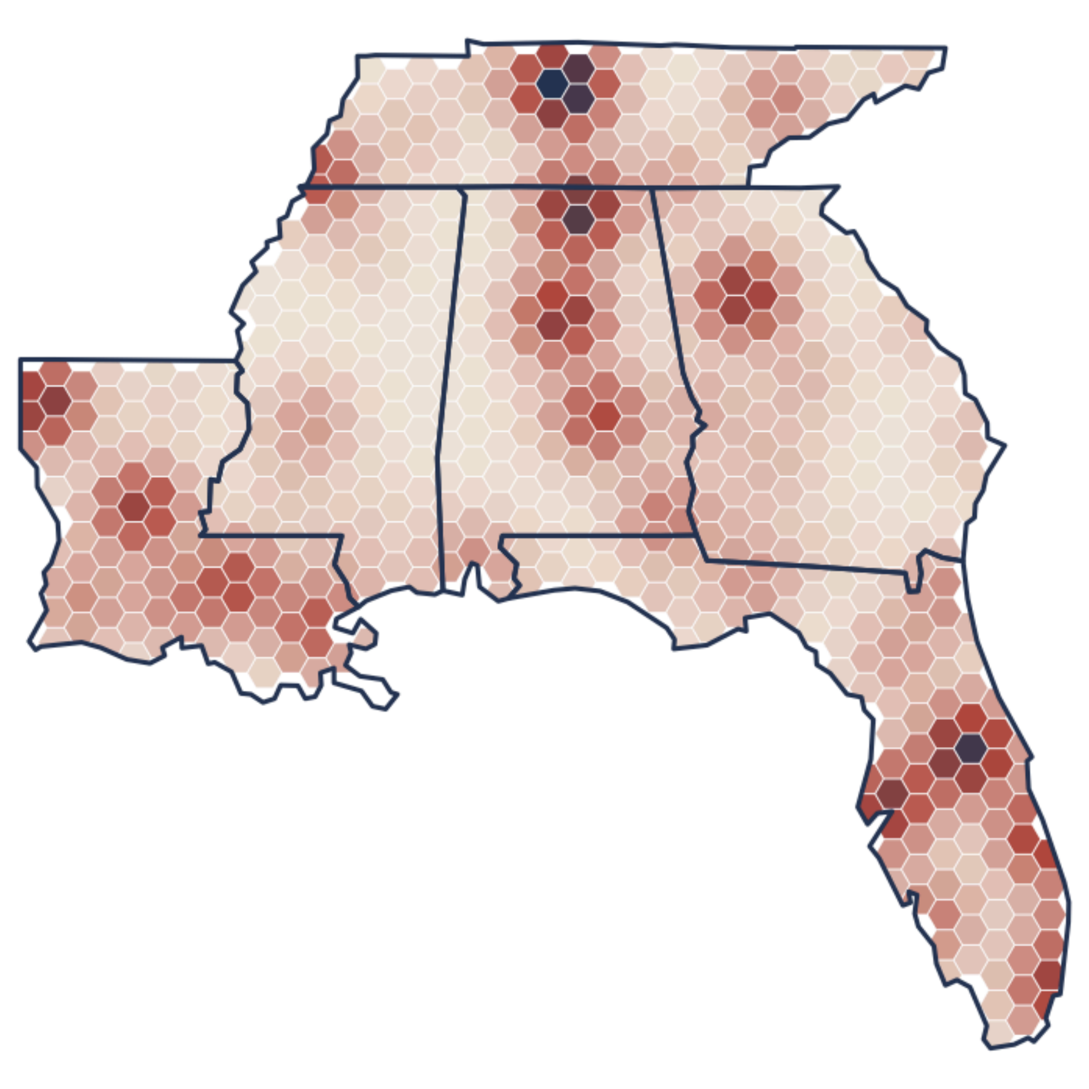
Google pays in Arkansas: Entergy Arkansas said Google will fund nearly $600 million in grid upgrades for its West Memphis data center, bringing at least $500 million in customer savings starting in 2028.

ON THE RADAR

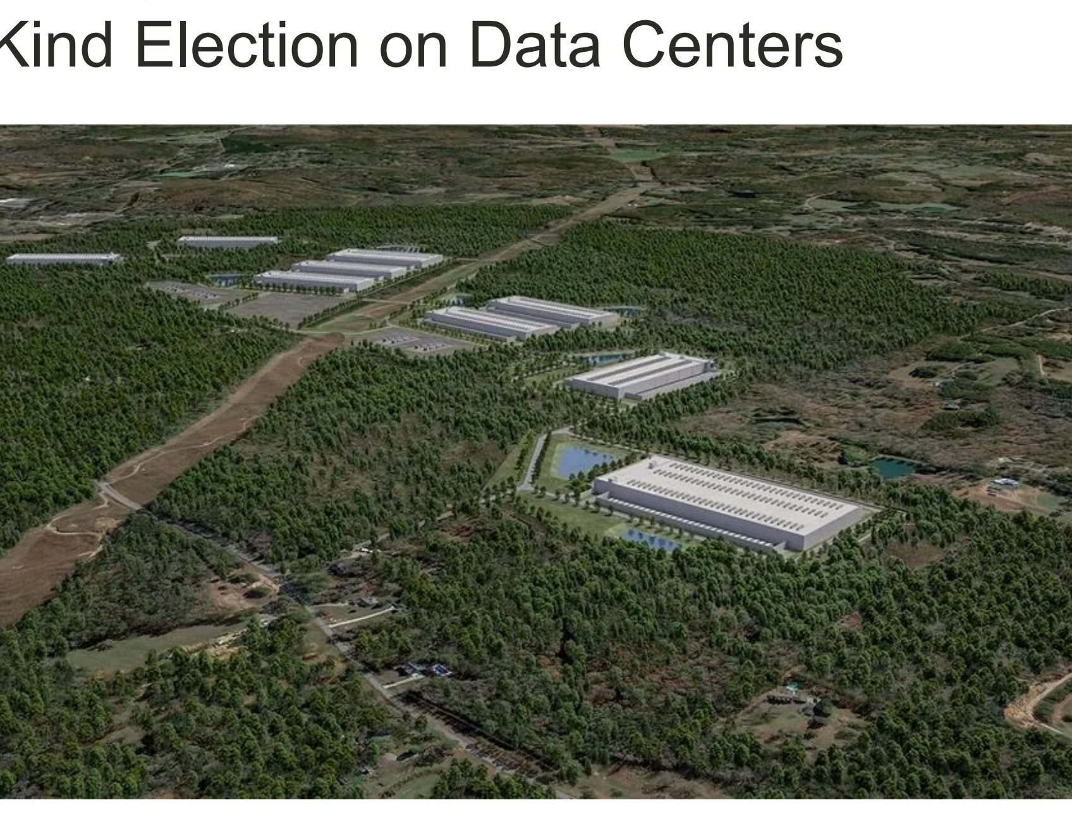
Over the past week, mentions were split almost evenly between online news (2,574) and TV broadcast (2,577), which together made up nearly 80% of the 6,605 total.

- X was the next biggest contributor at 734 mentions (11%), with radio adding 373 (6%).
- Facebook (138), YouTube (94) and Instagram (70) were each 1–2%, and forums, blogs, print, Pinterest, comments and TikTok were negligible.

Volume dipped to a weekly low of 394 mentions on Oct. 18, then surged Oct. 19–21, peaking at 1,450 on Oct. 20.



Florida led the region by a wide margin (965 mentions), followed by Alabama (604), Louisiana (458), Tennessee (382) and Georgia (340); Mississippi trailed at 92.



Coverage Spotlight: Thousands of Georgia Voters Push for First-of-Its-Kind Election on Data Centers

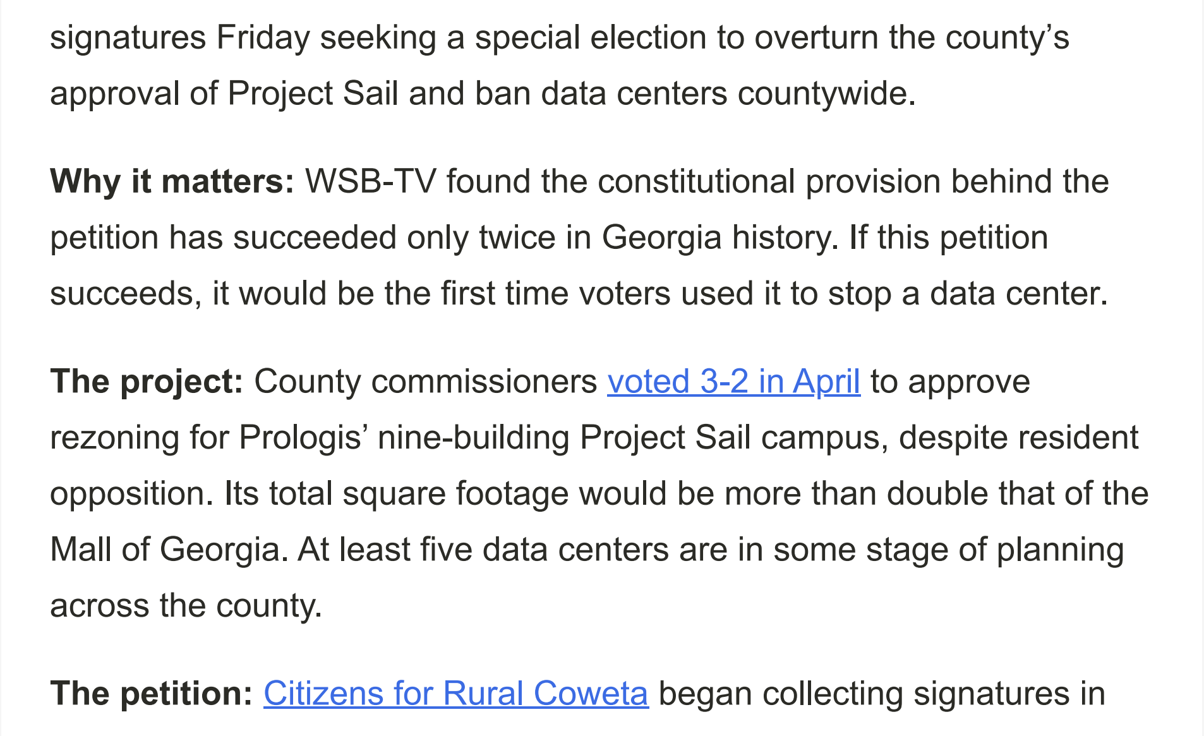


Photo Credit: Coweta County Board of Commissioners

Publication & Date: WSB-TV; Tuesday, October 20

Coweta County residents filed a petition with more than 14,000 signatures Friday seeking a special election to overturn the county's approval of Project Sail and ban data centers countywide.

Why it matters: WSB-TV found the constitutional provision behind the petition has succeeded only twice in Georgia history. If this petition succeeds, it would be the first time voters used it to stop a data center.

The project: County commissioners voted 3-2 in April to approve rezoning for Prologis' nine-building Project Sail campus, despite resident opposition. Its total square footage would be more than double that of the Mall of Georgia. At least five data centers are in some stage of planning across the county.

The petition: Citizens for Rural Coweta began collecting signatures in May, and some residents waited hours in line to sign.

- Because Coweta has more than 50,000 residents, the petition needed signatures from at least 10% of voters registered in the last general election. If approved by voters, the measure would also ban cryptocurrency mining.

What's next: The probate judge has 60 days to determine whether the petition is valid. If it is, an election must be held 60 to 90 days after the filing, which could put a vote in mid-January.

The other side: Prologis said it respects the county's process, but the petition "does not change our commitment to Project Sail." The company noted that some residents and community leaders spoke in support of the project at the April hearing.

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NATIONAL NEWS

The Hill: Trump says new data centers must make their own electricity

- Trump posted Wednesday that new large data centers are "mandated by me" to generate their own power and give or sell the excess to local communities.

Quartz: AI Data Centers Want More Power. Washington Scrambles to Write New Rules

- The Federal Energy Regulatory Commission is drafting a new proposal that would expand its authority to manage the country's surging demand for electricity.

The New York Times: Meta Raises Its A.I. Spending, as Cash Pressures Grow

- Meta raised the floor of its 2026 capital spending to $135 billion, mostly for data centers, as its free cash flow turned negative last quarter.

The Washington Post: Most Americans Want to Halt All Data Center Construction

- A new ABC News/Washington Post/Ipsos poll found that 72 percent of Americans oppose building a new data center where they live, including 58 percent of Republicans. Opposition to a nearby data center was highest in rural areas, at 78 percent.

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